(BJP) government had faced a big embarrassment when the Uttarakhand Public Service Commission (UKPSC) exam had to be cancelled last year after it came to light that the paper had been leaked and sold to several candidates.

The Dhami regime is now ready to crack the whip, backed by a strong anti-copying law, which makes the offence cognisable (arrest can be made without a warrant), non-bailable and non-compoundable (no compromise is allowed between parties). As for the penalty, an applicant found guilty of cheating during an exam can face up to a three-year jail term and a minimum fine of Rs 5 lakh. If caught again, the penalty can go up to a 10-year jail term along with a minimum Rs 10 lakh fine. More importantly, the law provides for a life sentence and a fine of up to Rs 10 crore to facilitators of cheating (or paper leak), including the printing press, coaching institute managements or any other related service provider. All the properties earned using unfair means can also be seized—keeping the option for "bulldozer justice" open.

That said, the menace is hardly limited to Uttarakhand: paper leaks are rampant across India, including in UP, Bihar, West Bengal, Rajasthan, MP, Punjab and Gujarat, to name a few states. The bitter experience of UP criminalising copying in the '90s prevented other states from bringing in a strong law. Now that the Dhami regime has ventured to experiment with a stringent law once again, its implementation and fallout will be keenly observed by all state governments struggling to curb the menace. The question is—will they copy the hill state's ordinance in toto? ■

CHHATTISGARH/ MAOIST VIOLENCE

THE POLITICS OF THE BASTAR MURDERS

By Rahul Noronha

It's not uncommon in India to see the run-up to an election being marred by violence. But Chhattisgarh, which goes to the polls at the end of the year, is recording a variation on the theme. A spate of killings of BJP leaders by left-wing extremists in the forested Bastar region has sparked off a war of words between the ruling Congress and the main opposition party.

Those in the security establishment see the murders as the manifestation of a changed Maoist strategy. But the incidents are bound to impact political activity in this belt. Bastar, with its 12 assembly seats, is crucial for both the BJP and the Congress—more so for the former, which views its road to Raipur as passing through the region.

Sagar Sahu, the BJP's vice-president for Narayanpur district, was shot dead by two assailants at his house in Chotedongar on February 10— just a day ahead of BJP national president J.P. Nadda's visit to Bastar, a fact not without significance. On February



MURDER MOST FOUL
Relatives of BJP leader Sagar Sahu, who was shot dead by Maoists, grieving at Narayanpur